Guru Arjan's supervision. On its compilation, the Granth Sahib was installed for the first time in Harmandir Sahib in 1604.

It was due to his insistence on retaining one particular hymn in the Granth Sahib and, subsequently, due to his refusal to embrace Islam that Guru Arjan was martyred at Lahore in 1604, under orders from the Mughal emperor Jehangir. Incidentally, Operation Blue Star was launched on the day Sikh pilgrims had gathered in the Golden Temple complex that year to mark the anniversary of Guru Arjan's martyrdom.

In the eighteenth century, Harmandir Sahib was desecrated a number of times. But the three better remembered cases of desecration are those of 1737, 1757 and 1762. In 1737, the Mughal governor of Lahore ordered the arrest and execution of Bhai Mani Singh, the custodian of Harmandir. Musa Khan (Massa) Ranghar, who was appointed administrator of Amritsar, started using Harmandir as a place of entertainment by getting dancing girls to perform there. In August 1740, two Sikhs entered Harmandir under the guise of tax collectors and beheaded 'Massa' Ranghar.

In April 1757, Ahmad Shah Abdali (Durrani) raided north India for the fourth time. While he was on his way back to Kabul from Delhi taking with him young Hindu men and women as captives, a group of Sikhs led by seventy-five-year-old Baba Deep Singh attacked Abdali's convoy near Kurukshetra and freed a large number of prisoners, also relieving Abdali's convoy of some of the valuables it was carrying. In retaliation, Harmandir's sacred sarovar (pool) was filled with filth and the entrails of slaughtered animals, including cows. After Abdali's return to Afghanistan, Baba Deep Singh marched towards Harmandir Sahib to liberate it and was joined by thousands of Sikhs along the way. On 13 November 1757, he died fighting in an attempt to liberate Harmandir Sahib.

In 1762, Ahmad Shah Abdali returned and blew up Harmandir Sahib with gunpowder and again filled its sacred sarovar with filth and the entrails of slaughtered cows before returning to Afghanistan. In 1764, Baba Jassa Singh Ahluwalia defeated the local Afghan contingent in the battle of Sirhind, collected donations and rebuilt Harmandir Sahib. It came to be known as swaran mandir (Golden Temple) after some of its portions were plated with gold in